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HOW TO GET
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Vol. 3. JULY, 1896. **No. 31**
Published Monthly.

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HOW TO GET A GOVERNMENT POSITION.

For a young man or young lady without private means, or with but a small income, the Civil Service opens a channel for pleasant work, regular hours, and fairly good remuneration. Government employees know what to expect, can calculate exactly on the punctual payment of the amount assigned to their respective positions, and are certainly not expected to injure their health or mental powers by overwork; in addition to which, in some positions, at the end of a certain number of years they will find themselves in a position to retire from further labor, with a certain, if moderate, income for the remainder of their lives.

The Civil Service System of the United States has been extended until it is now the only avenue of entrance to thousands of lucrative positions. The examinations are competitive. Suppose that one hundred candidates write at a particular Civil Service examination in the city of Boston, that sixty-five of these pass the examination and that there are forty vacancies to be filled. Of these sixty-five successful candidates, the forty who stand highest are chosen for the positions, the candidate, whether man or woman, standing first, taking the best position, the candidate standing second, taking the second best position, and so on down. This makes it very desirable and important that intending candidates spare neither time nor money in preparing themselves thoroughly for the examination.

Limitations of space make it impossible to give more than a general outline of the examinations and a few practical hints as to the best method of studying for the examinations.

Requests for blank forms of application for competitive examination for admission to the Classified Civil Service and all regular applications for such examinations shall be made—

1. For Classified Departmental Service, to the United States Civil Service Commission, Washington, D. C.
2. Classified Customs Service: Sec. of Customs Board of Civil Service Examiners, —— ———

3. Classified Postal Service, to the Sec. of the Postal Board of Civil Service
Examiners, —— ———

Give in the blank spaces the name of the town at which you wish to enter
the service.

Requirements.

Applicants for ordinary positions must be not less than 16 or more than 35 years of age. Messengers, stampers and other juvenile assistants not under 14. In Classified Departmental and Customs Service are 18 to 45. Age limitations do not apply to those honorably discharged from service in the army or navy who served in the late war.

Three citizens to whom you are known must fill out blank forms giving statements as to your character, etc., if you desire to enter departmental service.

Blank Form of Application.

As indicated in the “Directions to Candidates,” send for a blank form of application, fill it out carefully, according to the directions given, and forward to the Commission or Board named thereon. The following questions are selected from the application form used by applicants for admission to the classified departmental service:—

Your Christian name and surname? Are you a citizen of the United States? Of what state or territory are you a (legal) resident? How long have you been a resident thereof? Your present post-office address? The day and year of your birth? Your age last birthday? Where were you born? Your education? (Kind of school, etc.) How old when you finally quitted school? Are you married? How many members of your family are in the classified service? Have you ever been convicted of, or are you under indictment for, any crime? Do you habitually use intoxicating beverages to excess? Are you physically capable of a full discharge of the duties of the position to which you are seeking appointment? Have you any defect of sight? Of hearing? Of speech? Of limb? Have you been examined for the classified service since July 16, 1883? Particulars? Are you now in the service? Were you dismissed? Were you ever in the military service of the United States? Your place of abode during year of 18—. Your occupation during that year? Name of your employer, and his business? Present post-office address of employer?

Examination Rules.

1. Two examinations for each classified customs district and post office shall be held each year. In each customs district one commencing the first Tuesday of April and the second on the first Tuesday of October; in each post office one commencing on the first Tuesday of February and the second on the first Tuesday of August. The examinations continue from day to day until all applicants present upon regular notification have had an opportunity to be examined.
2. An applicant for a customs or a postal examination, cannot be examined at any other custom house or post-office than the one in which he is seeking to enter the classified service.
3. If an applicant fail to receive due notice of an examination, or if he shall give a reason satisfactory to the commission or the board of examiners for failure to attend an examination of which he may have received due notice, he shall be notified to attend the next examination for the same class or place.
4. Examiners in charge of any examination shall be diligent in securing fairness therein.
5. The examination sheets shall be numbered.
6. Each competitor shall be designated by a number, to be known as his examination number, which he must place in figures at the head of each examination sheet that he may use.
7. At the commencement of an examination, each competitor must fill the blanks in the "declaration sheet." He must also write his *examination number*, and nothing else upon an envelope; into this envelope he must put the declaration sheet, and then seal the envelope. The envelope thus sealed, must be delivered by the competitor to one of the examiners in charge, and it must not be opened until after the competitor's papers shall have been marked, and his general average ascertained.
8. As soon as the envelopes containing the declaration sheets shall have all been delivered, sheet 1 shall be given to the competitors, and, as soon as it

shall have been completed, sheet 2; and so on, each of the examination sheets in its order, according to its number, no competitor being allowed to have two or more sheets at the same time. If, through no fault of the competitor, a sheet is spoiled, the examiners in charge may destroy the spoiled sheet and give the competitor another sheet of the same number. The time when a competitor receives a sheet, and the time when he finishes it, must be stated at the top of the sheet.

9. The examiners in charge shall require every competitor, upon completion of each sheet, to surrender the sheet itself and all scrap-paper or other paper upon which he may have done preliminary work before writing his answers on the sheet.

10. The answers on examination papers must be written with ink; but preliminary work, on tablets or scrap-paper, may be done with pencil.

11. In the dictation exercise, the passage to be dictated shall first be read aloud for information, and then be dictated in groups of words, at the rate of not less than fifteen nor more than twenty-five words per minute. The examiner who reads the dictation must not repeat any group of words, or any word, dictated by him; but he must be careful in giving the dictation to pronounce each word distinctly.

12. Examiners must make to the whole class all explanations deemed necessary, and must not explain any question to any individual competitor.

13. After an examination shall have been commenced, no conversation nor communication of any kind shall be permitted between competitors.

14. No examination shall begin earlier than 9 A. M. or continue later than 6 P. M.

15. Every examination must be held in the presence of more than one examiner, and in the room set apart either permanently or temporarily for such examination. But examinations in typewriting and other subjects which would annoy other persons being examined (or which must necessarily be confined to one person at a time), may be held in some room convenient to the general examination room, but where they may be under the supervision of more than one examiner. No secret or private examination must be permitted.

16. Each examination, except the examination in book-keeping, or other examination especially excepted from this regulation, by the commission, must be completed on the day on which it is commenced.

17. Twenty minutes shall be allowed at the commencement of each examination for the work of filling the blanks of the declaration sheet and enclosing it in an envelope, and ten minutes for explanations and instructions by the examiner in charge. No allowance will be made for time spent for lunch or other purposes, either in or out of the examination room, and no unnecessary delay in passing the examination papers may be permitted by the examiner in charge.

18. All examination sheets whether completed or not must be turned in at the expiration of the time to which the examination is limited.

19. No competitor shall leave the room without giving notice of intention to do so, and shall not be permitted on his return to finish any sheet upon which he may have been at work.

20. Any competitor suspected of copying from another, or otherwise improperly obtaining information, shall, if proven guilty, have his papers cancelled.

21. Applicants must supply themselves with pen, ink, lead pencils, erasers, and in technical examinations with the necessary instruments.

22. Except by special permission no persons except the commissioners, examiners and competitors shall be allowed in the examination room.

23. No books, notes, maps or diagrams shall be permitted in room for the use of competitors.

24. A record of all non-competitive examinations shall be kept by the commission, and each customs and postal board shall, after each examination, report to the commission all the facts in relation thereto.

25. No request for the examination of an applicant out of his order as determined by the number of his application paper shall be granted.

26. An applicant who has for any reason been denied examination in his due order may appeal to the commission.

Marking of Papers.

1. As soon as practicable after an examination, the papers of the competitors shall be marked and the general average of each ascertained.
2. A competitor after receiving notice that he has passed or has failed to pass, may in person or by duly authorized agent, inspect, in the presence of an examiner, his examination papers, and if in his opinion injustice has in any way been done him, he may within thirty days after the receipt of notice, appeal to the commission, specifying particularly and in detail the cause of the complaint. The commission shall promptly decide all such appeals, and may, in the investigation thereof, direct the re marking of applicant's papers and change his general average. But no communication from a competitor, explanatory of errors presumed to have been made by him in said examination, shall receive attention.
3. No request to have the papers of a competitor marked out of their order shall be granted.

Subjects of Examination.

To test the fitness of applicants for admission to the classified departmental service, there shall be examinations as follows:—

COPYIST EXAMINATION. FOR PLACES OF \$900 PER YEAR AND UNDER.

1. Orthography (*spelling*).
2. Copying.
3. Penmanship.
4. Arithmetic: *to percentage*.

CLERK EXAMINATION. \$1000 PER YEAR AND UP.

1. Spelling.
2. Copying.
3. Penmanship.
4. Arithmetic: Fundamental Rules, Fractions, Percentage, Interest and Discount.
5. Book-keeping.
6. Grammar.
7. Letter Writing.
8. Geography, History and Government of the United States.

For places which in the opinion of the commission certain technical, professional or scientific knowledge, or knowledge of other language than English, a special or supplementary examination. Each special examination shall embrace in addition to the special subject upon which the applicant is to be examined, such part of the clerk examination as the commission may deem necessary to determine his fitness for the position to be filled.

**EXAMINATION FOR CLASSIFIED POSTAL SERVICE
SHALL BE:**

1. Spelling.
2. Copying.
3. Penmanship.
4. Arithmetic: *to percentage*.
5. Grammar.
6. Letter Writing.
7. Geography, History and Government of the United States.

CARRIER EXAMINATION.

1. Spelling.
2. Copying.
3. Penmanship.
4. Fundamental Rules of Arithmetic.
5. Geography of the United States.
6. Knowledge of the Local Post Office Delivery.
7. Physical Tests.

MESSENGER EXAMINATION.

1. Spelling.
2. Copying.
3. Penmanship.
4. Fundamental Rules of Arithmetic.
5. Physical Tests.

This examination shall also be used for applicants for positions of piler, stamper, junior clerk or other places requiring chiefly manual labor.

General Rules.

No person now serving in the army or navy shall be examined for admission to the classified service until the written consent of the head of the department under which he is enlisted shall have been communicated to the commission.

The commission may refuse to examine an applicant who would be physically unable to perform the duties of the place to which he desires appointment.

No question in any examination shall be so framed as to elicit information concerning the political or religious opinions or affiliations of competitors; and no discrimination in examination, certification or appointment shall be made by the commission, the examiners, or the appointing or nominating officer in favor of or against any applicant, competitor, or eligible because of his political or religious opinions or affiliations. Any appointing or nominating officer who shall make inquiries concerning, or in any other way attempt to ascertain, the political or religious opinions or affiliations of any eligible, or who shall discriminate in favor of or against any eligible because of the eligible's political or religious opinions or affiliations, shall be dismissed from office.

Every applicant for examination for the classified departmental service must support the statements of his application paper by certificates of persons acquainted with him, residents of the state, territory, or district in which he claims *bona fide* residence; and the commission shall prescribe the form and number of such certificates.

A false statement made by an applicant, or connivance by him with any person to make on his behalf a false statement in any certificate required by the commission and deception or fraud practiced by an applicant, or by any person on his behalf with his consent, to influence an examination, shall be good cause for refusal to examine such applicant, or for refusing to mark his papers after examination.

All examinations shall be prepared and conducted under the supervision of the commission; and examination papers shall be marked under rules made

by the commission, which shall take care that the marking-examiners do not know the name of any competitor in an examination for admission whose papers are entrusted to them.

Any person not under twenty years of age may make application for admission to the classified departmental service, blank forms for which purpose shall be furnished by the commission.

Suggestions for Study.

If it is intended to make application for admission to civil service examination it is wise to make preparation by taking up a regular course of study in the branches which your examination will come.

The best course of study and the most practical knowledge can be gained by having a friend read a newspaper paragraph, allowing you to write it down while it is being read. This exercise is particularly effective as it gives you a knowledge of spelling, punctuation, and rapid and improved penmanship.

The spelling of the names of the various states and territories and their proper abbreviations is also necessary.

Other abbreviations in common use should also be studied and understood, such as: inst., prox., ult., P. M., Ont., Can., P. Q., N. F., Man., etc. A general idea of the history and Government of the United States is also required. The rapidity with which you can read copy and correct business letters or other papers in which the writing is not particularly good will also be a help to you.

One of the most important branches in many of the departments is arithmetic, and a systematic course of studies should be taken up before the time of the examination.

There is no danger of knowing too much, and care in studying systematically will amply repay the time it takes. It is almost impossible for anyone who has been out of school for two or three years or more to pass an ordinary school examination, however much they may have gained in general practical knowledge.

The examination given is comparatively simple and does not require a college education, but can easily be passed by anyone who is a graduate of a grammar school, if a little time and care is devoted to preparation for the examination.

A position of this kind is profitable and permanent, with reasonable hours; it is worth trying for.

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Transcriber's Note:

Punctuation has been made consistent.

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